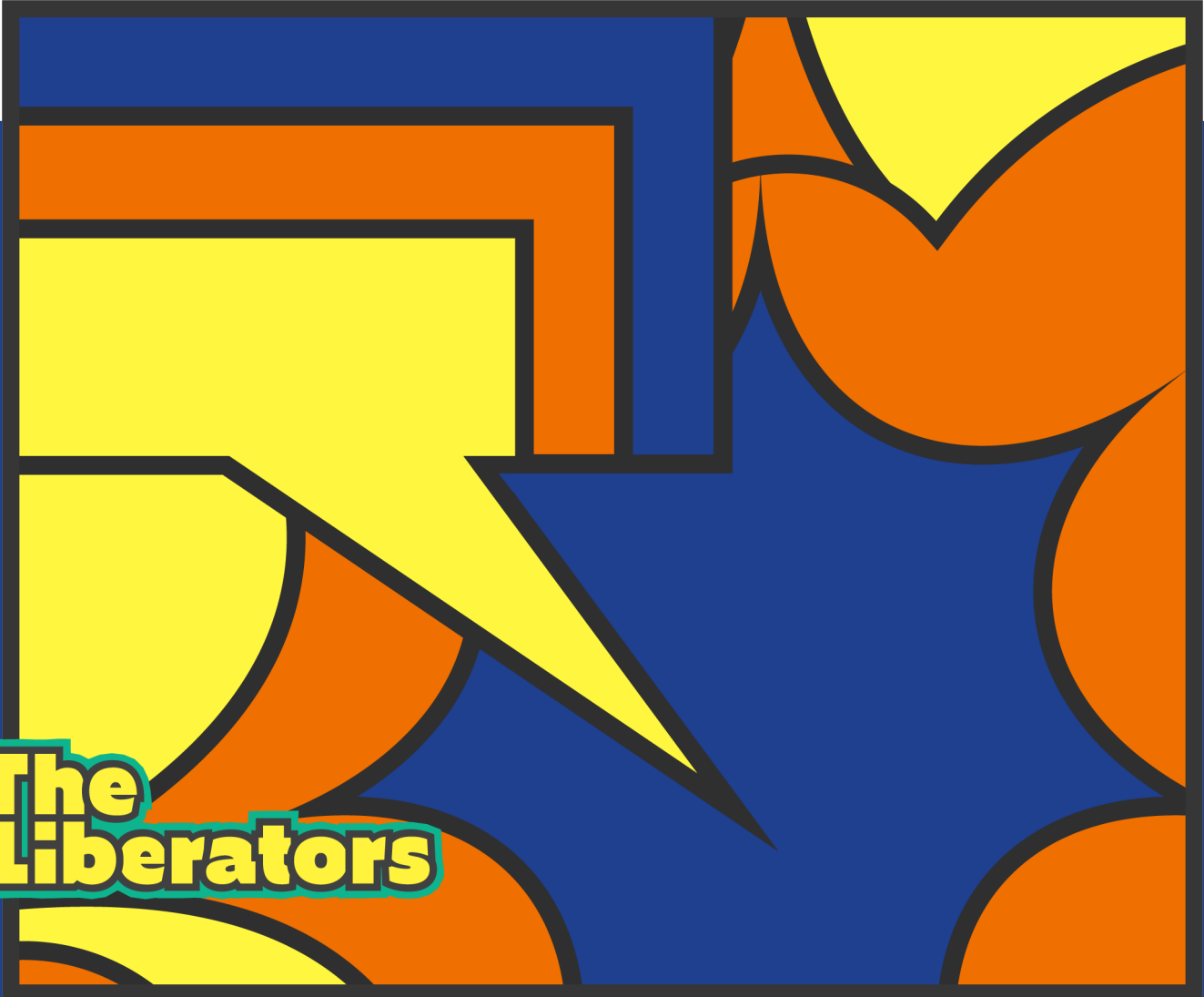


Use Compliment Postcards To Create Safety

A simple experiment to improve team morale and psychological safety by recognizing the contributions of others

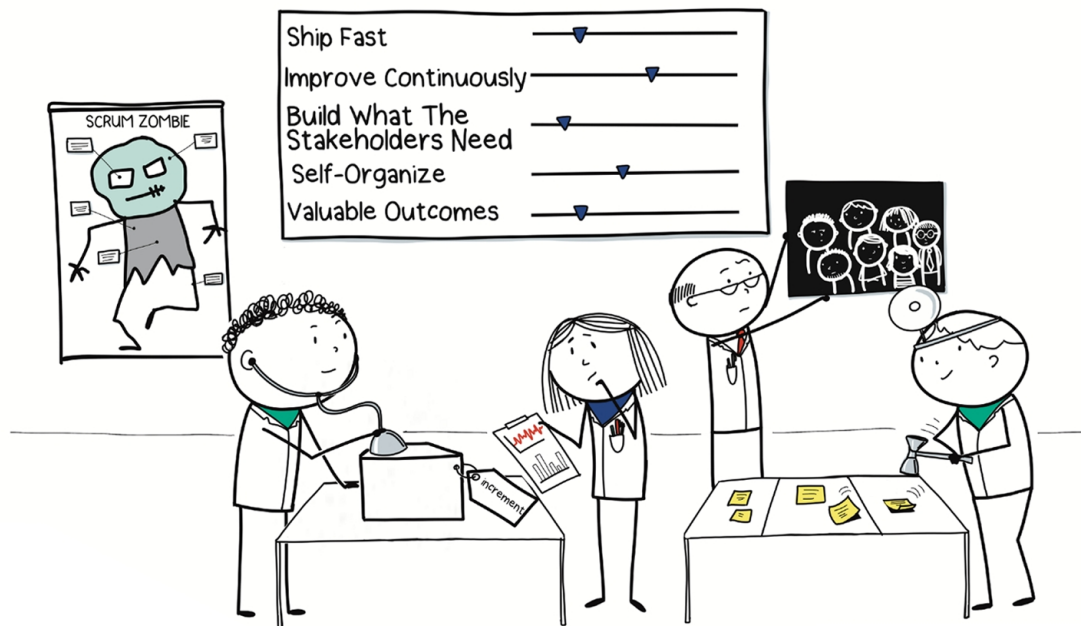


**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This Experiment

Continuous improvement is the lifeblood of Scrum teams. But Scrum teams that lack psychological safety find it hard to learn and improve. Both require trying new things and talking openly about mistakes.

One way to create a safe environment is to help teams recognize and appreciate helpful contributions as they happen. This doesn't always come naturally, and this experiment is designed to help teams learn how to do this. This experiment was inspired by a Scrum Master we worked with – Barry Meijer – and has similarities with Management 3.0's excellent Kudo Cards.



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Filling in a compliment card isn't hard if you set the example.

Impact On Survival



Being more appreciative of what people contribute is a simple – but very important – way to get out of Zombie Scrum.

Steps



To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Get a set of empty postcards. We always like to bring cards with motivational texts, odd pictures, and other nice encouragements. You can also switch for the aforementioned Kudo Cards.
2. At the end of a Scrum event, give people an opportunity to fill in a compliment postcard for someone else who was present. This is optional. Encourage people to look for moments when someone else contributed to the team's ability to learn and grow. For example, when someone shared an intriguing observation, raised a thought-provoking question, or did something out of their comfort zone. The Sprint Retrospective, Sprint Planning, and the Sprint Review are the most natural opportunities.
3. Give everyone the opportunity to give the postcard to the person they wrote it for. Afterward, collect the postcards somewhere in the team room.
4. Leave a stack of compliment cards in the team room for use when an opportunity presents itself. Whenever someone fills in a postcard, they give it to the person it is for. Afterward, add the postcard to the existing set in the team room.

Our Findings



- Only honest compliments matter. Instead of making this an obligatory activity for the whole team to sit through, let people write compliment cards during breaks or after the event. This reduces the peer pressure to write cards "because everyone else is doing it".
- Model the desired behavior as the initiator of this experiment. Make an effort to appreciate contributions that may not seem helpful at first glance, but do help the team learn and grow. For example: taking a personal risk by gently challenging a decision that the majority of a team agrees with or admitting to a mistake.
- When you work with virtual teams, you can replace physical compliment postcards with virtual ones. For example, you can create a #complimentcard channel in Slack or share a simple template that people can fill in.

More Resources

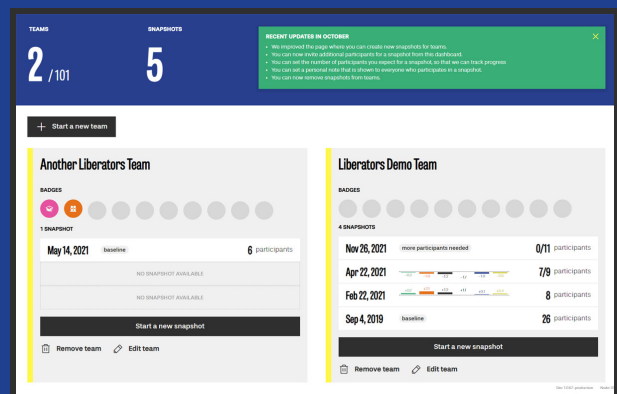
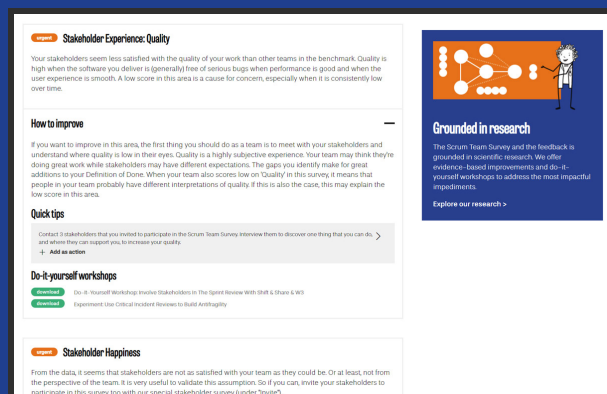
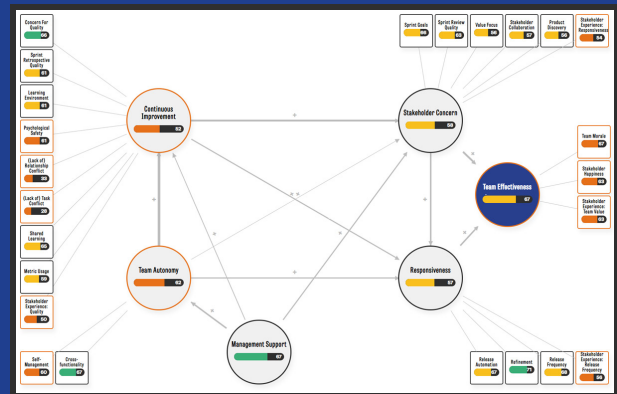
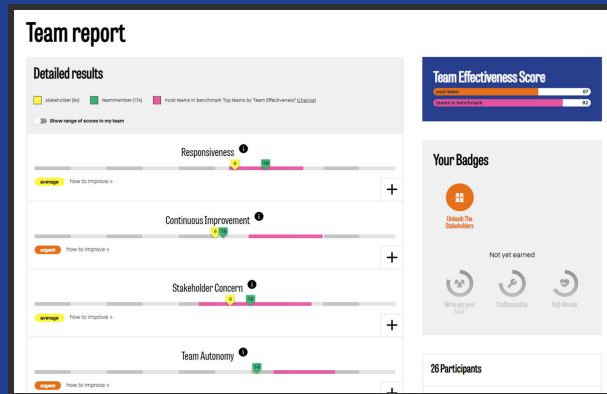


- Tool: [You can also give taco's](#) when you want to recognize someone's contribution (thanks to Rasheed Raya for setting the example).
- Tool: [Kudo Cards](#), created by Management 3.0, are also a nice way to show appreciation.



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

Awesome content for awesome teams

We unleash teams with our [blogposts](#), our [podcast](#), our [newsletter](#), our [videos](#), and our frequent [meetups](#). While we offer most of this for free, we also have plenty of premium content in [our webshop](#) for you to explore.

Supported by the community

We are super proud that The Liberators is almost entirely funded by the community. If you appreciate our work too, you can already support us for 12 dollars/year by becoming a [patron](#). In return, you gain free access to premium content, we share our work-in-progress and involve you in creating more awesome content.



Thank you for respecting our work!

We work hard to create high-quality content that puts you in a position to unleash your team. We're sure you appreciate that a lot of our time and money goes into this. At the same time, content like this is our main source of income. It's what pays our bills :)

If you purchased this content, we ask only that you treat our work with respect and don't share it with people outside your team. If you stumbled on it elsewhere without paying for it, and it offers you value, would you consider [supporting us too](#)? You can also check [out our other offerings](#).